disastrous for a sector that employs 422,000 artisans, of whom 280,000 are registered.

"About 80 per cent of high-end carpets and pashmina products go to the US," says Mujtaba Qadri of Me and K, a Srinagar-based firm targeting global buyers digitally. "With European markets already hit by war-driven uncertainty, the luxury segment is under severe strain."

That segment accounts for the bulk of exports in value terms, due to the high-priced items, and sell all year around. But for made-to-order papier-mâché baubles, which make up only a sliver of the total value but support an entire artisanal segment,

Takeaways

- **Kashmir's handicraft exports have seen a steep decline: from Rs 2,175 crore in 2014-15 to Rs 733 crore**
- **Overseas orders have frozen due to tariffs and geopolitical turmoil**
- **Traders hope for best in ongoing trade negotiations**

Christmas is harvest season: sales surge by a factor of 30 in Q3.

Fifteen Kashmiri crafts hold GI tags, and chief minister Omar Abdullah recognises these as a key employment generator. Yet, even official initiatives have been unable to stop a receding tide, as young talent gets driven away by meagre returns. Veterans like Shirazi blame inadequate R&D. "Our products aren't keeping up with global design trends," he says.

Hopes now rest on the India-US trade talks yielding a 25 per cent tariff cut initially. Also, the Free Trade Agreement with the EU—if India can insulate it from the 'carbon border' clause that imposes pollution costs from January. Christmas would have passed white-knuckled by then. ■

TUSHAR TANKARIYA



▶ GUJARAT

Grim Reaper Stalks Gujarat

The rising graph of extreme weather events in Gujarat is matched by its mounting agrarian debt. Result: a string of farmer suicides in one month, after one spell of heavy unseasonal rain

By **Jumana Shah**